

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Restaurant Serving English



Learner workbook

Work with realistic cases, develop your own response, and use the answer section after you have tried the tasks.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For Restaurant servers, food runners, and dining-room service staff.

All people, prices, policies, counts, and incidents are fictional language practice, not food-safety, allergy, alcohol-service, legal, or payment-processing training. Follow workplace training and local requirements. Ingredient and cross-contact questions need the designated kitchen lead; do not guarantee suitability. This course concerns table service, not restaurant management.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

Open this course on [English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Confirming seats and order details

Clarify an ambiguous modifier and confirm the complete order.

02 Explaining menu choices and prices

Compare complete menu options without hiding an extra charge.

03 Receiving an allergy question

Acknowledge a stated allergy and identify the information still needed.

04 Coordinating courses and delays

Report an actual delay while keeping approximate timing clear.

05 Correcting a dish without blame

Acknowledge a specific mismatch and agree what happens next.

06 Explaining and splitting a bill

Distinguish equal payment shares from item-based bills.

07 Agreeing on clearing and shared service

Get permission to clear specific items without rushing the table.

08 Handing over a live section

Name each table's status and get the incoming server's acknowledgment.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop to choose a vocabulary, grammar, role-play, or new-dialogue activity.

LESSON 01 / READ AND NOTICE

Confirming seats and order details

Clarify an ambiguous modifier and confirm the complete order.

SITUATION

Table 12 has three covers. Seat one orders mushroom pasta, seat two orders a salad with dressing separately, and seat three has not chosen. The phrase 'no onions' was spoken without a clear seat reference. Clarify before sending the order.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

cover - One diner counted for restaurant table service.

seat number - A numbered position at a table used to match an order to a diner.

modifier - An order detail that changes the standard dish, such as sauce on the side.

read-back - A spoken repetition of an order so the guest can correct it.

Useful word combinations

take an order: record what each diner requests

confirm the seat number: match the dish to the correct diner

put the sauce on the side: request a separate serving of sauce

read the order back: repeat the details before sending them

LESSON 01 / LANGUAGE AND PRACTICE

Attach each change to a dish

3. Notice the language

A modifier needs a dish and a diner. 'On the side' means separately, not omitted. Ask a focused question before reading back the order.

Was ___ for your ___ or for ___?

I have ___ for seat ___, with ___.

You're still deciding on ___; is that right?

Compare this wording: Two salads, one different.

Clearer: One salad for seat two, dressing on the side and no onions.

The revised order identifies the diner and both changes.

4. Check the language

1. Guest: The dressing should come separately, not be left out.

Server: I'll request it ___.

A. mixed through the salad

B. poured over the salad

C. without dressing

D. on the side

2. Server: I heard 'no onions,' but not which dish.

Guest: It was my salad.

Server: Could you confirm ___?

A. in which seat are you sitting

B. which seat are you sitting in

C. which seat do you sit in

D. which seat you are sitting in

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Whose onion request?

Table 12: the three-cover order in the case.

- 01 • Server:** I caught the request for no onions, but which dish does that apply to?
- 02 • Guest:** My salad, please. My friend wants the mushroom pasta exactly as it normally comes.
- 03 • Server:** Thank you. Are you also the person who asked for dressing on the side?
- 04 • Guest:** Yes, I want the dressing separately, not removed from the order altogether, please.
- 05 • Server:** Then seat two has the salad, no onions, with dressing in a separate serving.
- 06 • Guest:** That's right. The person beside the window hasn't chosen a main course yet.
- 07 • Server:** I have seat one down for pasta and seat three as still deciding.
- 08 • Guest:** Could you give seat three another minute before you send the main course order?
- 09 • Server:** Certainly. I'll wait here a moment; would another menu help with the choice?
- 10 • Guest:** Yes, please. The third menu is underneath our coats, and another would be useful.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Moving chairs after ordering

Two diners have swapped seats before a runner arrives.

01 • Runner: I have the vegetable tart for seat one. Did anyone change seats after ordering?

02 • Guest: Yes, we swapped so my colleague could sit farther away from the speaker.

03 • Runner: Thanks for telling me. Who ordered the tart with the small green salad?

04 • Guest: I did, and I'm now sitting beside the aisle rather than the window.

05 • Runner: Then this plate belongs here. The pasta is for your colleague by the window?

06 • Guest: Correct. Neither of us changed the dishes; we only moved to different chairs.

07 • Runner: I'll tell your server about the move so the dessert orders reach you correctly.

08 • Guest: Please do. We're ordering different desserts and would rather not switch plates again.

09 • Runner: I'll identify the dishes as I bring them, as well as checking the updated seats.

10 • Guest: That works. You can put the tart here, with the salad beside it.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A phrase lost in the noise

A server checks an incomplete order during a busy lunch.

01 • Server: I'm sorry, the music covered your last words. Was that soup and a sandwich?

02 • Guest: Soup instead of a sandwich, actually. I don't need both items for lunch.

03 • Server: Thank you for correcting that. Which soup would you like from today's two choices?

04 • Guest: The tomato soup, please, with the bread that appears beside it on the menu.

05 • Server: I have one tomato soup with bread. Would you like the small or large portion?

06 • Guest: The small one. I only have time for a light lunch before my meeting.

07 • Server: Let me read that back: one small tomato soup with bread, and no sandwich.

08 • Guest: Exactly. Could you also check whether my colleague's drink has already been ordered?

09 • Server: Your colleague asked me for sparkling water earlier, and that order is already in.

10 • Guest: Great. Then the soup is the only item you still need to add.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Confirming seats and order details

Table 12 has three covers. Seat one orders mushroom pasta, seat two orders a salad with dressing separately, and seat three has not chosen. The phrase 'no onions' was spoken without a clear seat reference. Clarify before sending the order.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Guest at seat two: confirm that no onions applies to your salad, not the pasta. Seat three needs another minute.

Second round: Seat one also wants dressing for a side salad. Keep that request separate from seat two's main salad.

Scenario 2 | Two similar side dishes

A table orders one baked potato and one portion of mashed potatoes. The server hears 'without butter' but cannot identify the dish.

Role A: Server: clarify the dish and repeat both side orders.

Role B: Guest: the baked potato is yours and you prefer it without butter; the mashed potatoes belong to your companion.

Possible opening: Was the no-butter request for the baked potato or the mashed potatoes?

Success checks

- Obtain the dish name.
- Attach the preference to the baked potato only.
- Read back both orders without inventing an ingredient claim.

Add a complication: The guest points instead of naming the dish, and both diners are holding menus.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 02 / READ AND NOTICE

Explaining menu choices and prices

Compare complete menu options without hiding an extra charge.

SITUATION

The fictional lunch set costs \$24 and includes a main and dessert. Steak adds a \$5 supplement. The a la carte steak is \$27 without dessert. Both steak options include potatoes. Explain the \$29 set steak option versus \$27 steak alone.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

a la carte - Ordered as a separate menu item with its own price.

set menu - A group of courses offered together for a stated price and stated choices.

supplement - An extra charge for a specified menu choice.

side dish - A smaller dish served alongside the main dish.

Useful word combinations

quote the supplement: state the extra charge for a menu choice

include a side: provide an accompaniment within the stated price

choose from the set menu: select within a grouped meal offer

compare like for like: compare options with the same included items

LESSON 02 / LANGUAGE AND PRACTICE

Explain what the price includes

3. Notice the language

Name the base price, any supplement, and what comes with each option. 'Whereas' introduces a contrast; it does not explain a cause.

___ costs ___ and includes ___.

The supplement brings the total to ___.

___ includes ___, whereas ___ does not.

Compare this wording: The steak is five dollars.

Clearer: The steak adds five dollars to the twenty-four-dollar set price.

A supplement is an addition, not the whole price.

4. Check the language

1. Guest: Is the five-dollar supplement the full price?

Server: No, it is ___ the set price.

A. added to

B. included in

C. deducted from

D. equal to

2. Guest: What's different about the two steak options?

Server: The set includes dessert, ___ the separate steak does not.

A. whereas

B. because

C. therefore

D. unless

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

The five-dollar misunderstanding

The lunch menu in the case is open between server and guest.

01 • Guest: The steak says five dollars underneath it. Is that really the price of the meal?

02 • Server: That's the supplement to the twenty-four-dollar set menu, making the steak set twenty-nine dollars.

03 • Guest: Does that include the potatoes, or would those be another item on my bill?

04 • Server: Potatoes are included. The set also includes one dessert from the choices listed below.

05 • Guest: I don't usually have dessert. Is there a price for just the steak and potatoes?

06 • Server: Yes, the a la carte steak is twenty-seven dollars, with potatoes but without dessert.

07 • Guest: Then the extra two dollars on the set gets me one of those desserts?

08 • Server: For these two options, yes. The difference is two dollars and the included dessert.

09 • Guest: I'll choose the separate steak. Please don't add the set menu to my order.

10 • Server: Certainly. One a la carte steak with potatoes, priced at twenty-seven dollars before any applicable charges.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A starter is not a side

A diner compares a side salad with a larger starter salad.

01 • Guest: Could I have the starter salad with my main instead of the little side salad?

02 • Server: You can order the starter salad separately. It's larger and has its own menu price.

03 • Guest: I thought every salad was included when the main says it comes with a salad.

04 • Server: That refers to the side salad listed with the main, not the starter selection above.

05 • Guest: How much more would the starter cost, and could you remove the included side?

06 • Server: The starter is eight dollars. Removing the included side doesn't reduce this main's listed price.

07 • Guest: In that case, I'll keep the included salad and skip the larger starter today.

08 • Server: Of course. Would you like the main and its side brought together as listed?

09 • Guest: Yes, together. I was looking for a bigger salad, but the extra cost changes my choice.

10 • Server: I'll keep the standard main with its included side and no separately charged starter.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Today's special has a price

A server describes a special before the diner commits.

01 • Server: Today's special is a roasted vegetable tart with a green salad, priced at nineteen dollars.

02 • Guest: Is it part of the lunch set, or did you mean a separate special?

03 • Server: It's a separate item today. The lunch set choices are printed in this other section.

04 • Guest: Thank you. Does the special come with a drink, or is that priced separately?

05 • Server: Drinks are separate. The nineteen dollars covers the tart and its accompanying green salad.

06 • Guest: Could you compare that with the twenty-two-dollar lunch set before I choose between them?

07 • Server: The set includes a main and a drink, but its main choices don't include the tart.

08 • Guest: I'd rather have the tart and tap water, so please order the special for me.

09 • Server: Certainly. That's the nineteen-dollar special with tap water, and no set menu on the order.

10 • Guest: Exactly. Thanks for giving me the price before I had to ask about it.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Explaining menu choices and prices

The fictional lunch set costs \$24 and includes a main and dessert. Steak adds a \$5 supplement. The a la carte steak is \$27 without dessert. Both steak options include potatoes. Explain the \$29 set steak option versus \$27 steak alone.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Guest: you like steak but are unsure whether you want dessert. Ask for both complete prices.

Second round: The guest says 'So both are twenty-four dollars?' Correct the total without restarting the whole menu explanation.

Scenario 2 | A shared starter charge

A fictional menu lists a soup starter at \$7 and a sharing platter at \$18. The platter description says 'serves two'; \$18 is the whole platter price.

Role A: Server: explain price and suggested serving size.

Role B: Guest: ask whether 'serves two' means \$18 per person; choose the platter once clarified.

Possible opening: Is the sharing platter eighteen dollars each?

Success checks

- State that \$18 covers one platter.
- Separate serving size from a per-person price.
- Confirm whether the guest wants additional soup.

Add a complication: The guest also assumes two soups are included, but neither is included.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 03 / READ AND NOTICE

Receiving an allergy question

Acknowledge a stated allergy and identify the information still needed.

SITUATION

A guest at table 6 reports a sesame allergy and asks about a bun. The server has an old menu description, not current ingredient or cross-contact information. The kitchen lead is available to discuss the question before any order is sent.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

allergen - A substance that can trigger an allergic reaction; restaurant staff must check the relevant food information.

cross-contact - Unintended transfer of an allergen between foods or food-contact items.

ingredient list - A record of ingredients used in a food product or recipe.

dietary preference - A person's food choice or avoidance that is not necessarily an allergy.

Useful word combinations

flag an allergy: make the guest's stated allergy clearly visible to the responsible team

check the current ingredients: consult information for the actual item being served

relay the exact concern: pass on the guest's stated question accurately

avoid a blanket assurance: do not claim every preparation is suitable

LESSON 03 / LANGUAGE AND PRACTICE

Separate a description from a suitability claim

3. Notice the language

A menu description may omit ingredients. 'Not listed' differs from 'not present.' Keep ingredient information separate from cross-contact questions.

You mentioned an allergy to ____.

I haven't confirmed ____ for this item.

The kitchen lead can check ____ before you decide.

Compare this wording: It doesn't mention sesame, so it's fine.

Clearer: Sesame isn't mentioned here, but I need current ingredient and handling information.

Absence from a short description is not evidence of suitability.

4. Check the language

1. Guest: The short menu doesn't mention sesame.

Server: That tells us sesame is ____, not that it is absent.

A. not listed here

B. not used anywhere

C. removed on request

D. served separately

2. Kitchen lead: Is this a preference or a reported allergy?

Server: The guest explicitly reported an ____.

A. allergically

B. allergy

C. allergies

D. allergic

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

The bun description is incomplete

Table 6: the sesame question from the case.

- 01 • Guest:** I have a sesame allergy. Your bun description doesn't mention seeds; can I eat it?
- 02 • Server:** Thank you for telling me. That description doesn't confirm the current ingredients or handling arrangements.
- 03 • Guest:** I've had buns here before, although I don't remember whether this is the same one.
- 04 • Server:** I can't confirm this bun from your earlier visit. I'll ask the kitchen lead for today's ingredient list.
- 05 • Guest:** Please ask about sesame in the bread itself, not only the seeds on top.
- 06 • Server:** I'll pass on both that ingredient question and your concern about possible cross-contact.
- 07 • Guest:** Should I choose the burger now, or wait until those details have been checked?
- 08 • Server:** Let's leave the food order unsent while we get the information you need to decide.
- 09 • Guest:** All right. Please bring the kitchen lead if the answer needs a longer explanation.
- 10 • Server:** I will ask them to speak with you; your sesame question is still unresolved.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

An omission isn't an allergy label

A diner requests no coriander for taste, and the server checks meaning.

01 • Server: You asked for no coriander on the salad. Is that a preference or an allergy?

02 • Guest: It's a dietary preference. I don't enjoy coriander, but I'm not reporting an allergy.

03 • Server: Thank you. I'll record a preference to omit the coriander garnish, subject to the kitchen's confirmation.

04 • Guest: Does that mean you can remove every trace of coriander from the whole dish?

05 • Server: Not necessarily. The dressing may already contain it, and I haven't checked that recipe yet.

06 • Guest: Then could you check the dressing too? I'd choose another salad if it's mixed in.

07 • Server: Certainly. Is the concern the coriander flavor throughout the dish rather than the garnish alone?

08 • Guest: Exactly. I wouldn't want you to change the garnish while leaving the same flavor underneath.

09 • Server: I'll ask that specific question before entering the salad, then explain the available choices.

10 • Guest: Thanks. We can keep my order open while my friend orders their own meal.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Repeating the guest's actual words

A server speaks to the kitchen lead about a pending order.

01 • Server: Table nine reports a milk allergy and asks whether today's soup contains any milk ingredients.

02 • Kitchen lead: Have you sent the soup order already, or are they waiting for our answer?

03 • Server: They're waiting. I said I'd check the actual recipe and handling information before they choose.

04 • Kitchen lead: Good. Was their question only about a cream garnish, or the whole soup preparation?

05 • Server: The whole preparation. They specifically asked whether removing the garnish would settle the issue.

06 • Kitchen lead: I need the current recipe and allergen information; removing a garnish wouldn't settle that.

07 • Server: I'll keep the soup pending. Would you speak directly with them after checking those details?

08 • Kitchen lead: Yes. Tell them I'm gathering the current information and will come to their table.

09 • Server: I'll do that, without describing the soup as suitable before your discussion with the guest.

10 • Kitchen lead: Thank you. Please give me the table number again so I don't approach the wrong party.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Receiving an allergy question

A guest at table 6 reports a sesame allergy and asks about a bun. The server has an old menu description, not current ingredient or cross-contact information. The kitchen lead is available to discuss the question before any order is sent.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Guest: you have reported a sesame allergy and want reliable information before selecting food.

Second round: The guest says they ate the bun last month. Explain why the current item still needs checking.

Scenario 2 | A changed sauce supplier

A diner reports a peanut allergy. A colleague remembers an earlier sauce specification, but this week's sauce comes from a different supplier.

Role A: Server: explain the limit of the old information and request a current check.

Role B: Kitchen lead: you can review the new product information and speak to the diner; suitability is not yet established.

Possible opening: Does last week's ingredient sheet apply to this week's sauce?

Success checks

- Identify the supplier mismatch.
- Keep the food choice pending.
- Relay the allergy rather than infer a preference.

Add a complication: The old sheet has the same product name but a different supplier.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 04 / READ AND NOTICE

Coordinating courses and delays

Report an actual delay while keeping approximate timing clear.

SITUATION

Table 14 finished starters. Their mains were fired at 7:20. At 7:30 the kitchen estimates another eight minutes; one dish is still being prepared. The guests need to leave at 7:50. State the estimate and offer a timing discussion without guaranteeing completion.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

course - One stage of a meal, such as a starter or main dish.

fire - A kitchen instruction to begin preparing a course; its exact use varies by restaurant.

hold - A request to delay a specified order or course, not cancel it.

estimated wait - An approximate time before an item is expected, not a guarantee.

Useful word combinations

fire the mains: ask the kitchen to begin the main course

hold the next course: delay the next stage of the meal

check the ticket time: find when the order entered the kitchen

give a revised estimate: state the kitchen's updated approximate wait

LESSON 04 / LANGUAGE AND PRACTICE

Give an estimate with a reference point

3. Notice the language

Say when the estimate was obtained and whether it means additional time. Do not confuse 'held' with 'canceled' or 'being prepared' with 'ready'.

As of ___, the estimate is another ___.

___ is ready; ___ is still being prepared.

Does that leave enough time for ___?

Compare this wording: They'll be here soon.

Clearer: At seven thirty, the kitchen estimated another eight minutes.

The revised update gives usable timing without pretending certainty.

4. Check the language

1. Guest: Do you mean eight minutes in total from ordering?

Server: No, eight ___ minutes from now.

A. additional

B. completed

C. earlier

D. previous

2. Server: Please hold table five's mains; they're still eating starters.

Cook: So the mains are delayed, ___.

A. not canceled

B. ready for collection

C. already served

D. not yet ordered

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Eight more minutes

Table 14 at 7:30, following the timing case.

01 • Server: I've checked your mains. One dish is still being prepared; the estimate is another eight minutes.

02 • Guest: We ordered a while ago. Does that mean eight minutes from when you first sent it?

03 • Server: No, eight more minutes from this update. Your mains were fired at seven twenty.

04 • Guest: We need to leave at seven fifty. Is the eight-minute serving time definite now?

05 • Server: It's the kitchen's current estimate, not a guarantee. I'll make your departure time clear to them.

06 • Guest: Please do. We need time to eat, not simply have the plates arrive before we leave.

07 • Server: Understood. Would you prefer to wait on that estimate, or ask about another available option?

08 • Guest: Let's wait for now, but please tell us promptly if the kitchen's estimate changes again.

09 • Server: I will. I'll bring the bill when requested, so payment doesn't add avoidable delay.

10 • Guest: Please bring it with the mains. Let us know if the wait gets longer.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Holding dessert for a call

A diner requests a pause between the main and dessert.

01 • Guest: Could you hold our desserts? My colleague has stepped outside to take a work call.

02 • Server: Of course. Do you mean delay both desserts, or cancel one of them altogether?

03 • Guest: Delay both, please. We still want them, but we'd like to eat them together.

04 • Server: I'll ask the dessert station to hold the order if it hasn't already been prepared.

05 • Guest: Can you check that now? I don't want something sitting here while they're outside.

06 • Server: The station confirms the desserts haven't been prepared, so both are now on hold.

07 • Guest: Thank you. Should I wave when we're ready, or place the dessert order again?

08 • Server: Just let me know you're ready. The original order remains; there's no need to duplicate it.

09 • Guest: They're coming back now, but we'd like five more minutes before you request the desserts.

10 • Server: I'll leave the hold in place until you tell me to send that request.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

One plate isn't the whole table

A runner checks an incomplete pickup at the pass.

01 • Runner: I see three plates for table eight, but their ticket shows four main courses.

02 • Expediter: The fourth dish is finishing. Please don't describe the entire table as ready yet.

03 • Runner: Should I take these three now, or wait for the complete pickup from you?

04 • Expediter: Wait for my call on this table. I need to coordinate the final dish with the cook.

05 • Runner: The server is asking what to tell the guests. Do you have a current estimate?

06 • Expediter: About three more minutes, but I'll update you if that changes during the pickup.

07 • Runner: I'll tell the server the table isn't complete and the current estimate is three minutes.

08 • Expediter: Thanks. Please keep table eight separate from the two plates beside it for table eighteen.

09 • Runner: These three stay here while we wait for the fourth; table eighteen's two plates stay separate.

10 • Expediter: That's right. I'll call the full table number when each pickup is ready to leave.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Coordinating courses and delays

Table 14 finished starters. Their mains were fired at 7:20. At 7:30 the kitchen estimates another eight minutes; one dish is still being prepared. The guests need to leave at 7:50. State the estimate and offer a timing discussion without guaranteeing completion.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Guest: your departure time is fixed at 7:50. Ask whether eight minutes is a promise.

Second round: The estimate changes to twelve more minutes. Report the change and ask whether the guest wants available alternatives discussed.

Scenario 2 | Starter or main?

A guest orders soup and pasta and says 'together.' The restaurant normally serves starters before mains; neither item has been sent.

Role A: Server: check whether both dishes should arrive at once.

Role B: Guest: you want soup as your main while your companion eats pasta, not two courses for yourself.

Possible opening: When you say together, are these two mains for different people?

Success checks

- Clarify diners and timing.
- Correct the seat assignment.
- Read back simultaneous service as a request, not a guaranteed time.

Add a complication: The order screen currently assigns both dishes to one seat.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 05 / READ AND NOTICE

Correcting a dish without blame

Acknowledge a specific mismatch and agree what happens next.

SITUATION

Table 3 ordered vegetable pasta but received mushroom risotto. The ticket confirms pasta. The kitchen offers a pasta remake with an estimated ten-minute wait. The server may offer that replacement, but any bill adjustment needs the shift lead's review.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

remake - A newly prepared replacement for a dish that needs correction.

replacement - An item supplied in place of another item.

check-back - A brief return to the table to ask whether the food and service meet the guest's request.

service recovery - Actions taken to address a service problem and restore the guest's confidence.

Useful word combinations

acknowledge the mix-up: recognize that an order was confused

offer a replacement: propose another item within the options available

check back with the table: ask whether the correction addressed the concern

describe the mismatch: name how the served dish differs from the order

LESSON 05 / LANGUAGE AND PRACTICE

Correct the order and offer a choice

3. Notice the language

A useful apology names the error. Give the available option and its wait before asking for a choice; a replacement isn't automatically a refund.

You ordered ___, but we brought ___.

The replacement would take approximately ___.

Would you like ___, or would you prefer to speak with ___?

Compare this wording: That's what came from the kitchen.

Clearer: You ordered pasta; this is risotto. I'm sorry for the mix-up.

The correction addresses the guest's experience without shifting blame.

4. Check the language

1. Guest: I ordered pasta, not risotto.

Server: I'm sorry ___ the wrong dish.

A. we bringing

B. we have bring

C. we bring

D. we brought

2. Guest: Does 'remake' mean you remove the charge?

Server: Here, it means ____.

A. the charge removed from the bill

B. the existing dish reheated

C. the original order canceled

D. a newly prepared replacement dish

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Risotto instead of pasta

Table 3 receives the wrong main, as in the case.

01 • Guest: This looks like mushroom risotto. I ordered vegetable pasta when you took our main courses.

02 • Server: You're right; the ticket shows vegetable pasta. I'm sorry we brought the wrong dish.

03 • Guest: Can you replace it, and how long would I be waiting for the correct meal?

04 • Server: The kitchen offers a pasta remake with an estimated ten-minute wait. Would that work for you?

05 • Guest: My friend is already eating. Could you remove my dish from the bill as well?

06 • Server: I can arrange the replacement; a bill adjustment needs our shift lead's review.

07 • Guest: Please ask them, but go ahead with the pasta. I'd still like to eat.

08 • Server: I'll send the remake request and ask the lead to speak with you about the charge.

09 • Guest: Thank you. Please tell them I've accepted the replacement, not agreed about the final bill.

10 • Server: I will make that distinction clear, and check back when your pasta reaches the table.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A check-back gets a real answer

A guest says a meal is not what they expected.

01 • Server: How is the tart? Is there anything about your order that needs our attention?

02 • Guest: It's much smaller than I expected. I thought it would fill the whole plate.

03 • Server: I understand. The menu doesn't give a size, so I can see why expectations differed.

04 • Guest: I'm not saying it's badly made. I just need something more substantial for lunch.

05 • Server: Would you like to see the available side dishes and prices before deciding what to add?

06 • Guest: Yes, but please don't order anything automatically. I want to know the total first.

07 • Server: The potato side is four dollars, and the green salad is five dollars today.

08 • Guest: The potatoes sound better. Please add one portion, provided that price is the full item price.

09 • Server: Four dollars is the listed side price. I'll add one portion and confirm its expected wait.

10 • Guest: Thanks. That addresses my concern; I wanted a clearer choice, not a different tart.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Two plates crossed at pickup

A runner discovers that two complete orders were assigned to wrong tables.

01 • Runner: I checked the pickup tickets and think I brought table seven's tart to table eleven.

02 • Server: Table eleven has just questioned it. Their ticket shows a salad, not a tart.

03 • Runner: I'll tell the expediter exactly which dish and table were involved in the mix-up.

04 • Server: Please do. We need replacement instructions, not simply a guess about switching the plates back.

05 • Runner: Agreed. The tart has already reached the guest, so I'll explain that fact clearly.

06 • Server: I'll speak to table eleven and acknowledge the wrong dish while you check the replacement.

07 • Runner: The expediter confirms a fresh salad is being prepared, with a five-minute estimated wait.

08 • Server: I'll offer that estimate to the guest and ask whether the replacement still suits them.

09 • Runner: Do you need me to speak with table seven as well about their missing dish?

10 • Server: Yes, please explain that we're checking their order; don't claim it's already on its way.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Correcting a dish without blame

Table 3 ordered vegetable pasta but received mushroom risotto. The ticket confirms pasta. The kitchen offers a pasta remake with an estimated ten-minute wait. The server may offer that replacement, but any bill adjustment needs the shift lead's review.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Guest: you ordered pasta and have limited patience for a ten-minute wait. Ask about the bill.

Second round: The guest declines a replacement. Accept the choice and bring the shift lead into the bill discussion.

Scenario 2 | The sauce arrived on the food

A guest requested sauce separately but receives sauce over the dish. The ticket confirms the separate-sauce request. The kitchen offers a remake in eight minutes; no price adjustment is approved.

Role A: Server: apologize, describe the remake option, and check the guest's choice.

Role B: Guest: you want the correct dish but need to know the wait.

Possible opening: I asked for the sauce on the side; this plate has it on top.

Success checks

- Acknowledge the ticketed request.
- Distinguish an available option from a started remake.
- Confirm the guest's choice before reporting it to the kitchen.

Add a complication: The guest asks whether the remake is already being prepared, but you haven't requested it yet.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 06 / READ AND NOTICE

Explaining and splitting a bill

Distinguish equal payment shares from item-based bills.

SITUATION

Three diners have a fictional \$72 total with all listed charges included. They request 'three ways': this could mean equal payments or separate checks by item. The restaurant supports either before payment. Ask which they mean; equal shares would be \$24.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

itemized bill - A bill showing separate dishes, drinks, and other charges.

split payment - Payment of one bill using more than one payment contribution.

separate checks - Individual bills for different diners or groups at the same table.

service charge - A charge added for service under the restaurant's stated policy, distinct from an optional extra tip.

Useful word combinations

split the bill evenly: divide the amount into equal shares

allocate an item: place a specific charge on a particular check

query a charge: ask why an amount appears on the bill

bring a corrected bill: provide an updated statement after an error is confirmed

LESSON 06 / LANGUAGE AND PRACTICE

Check the meaning of 'split'

3. Notice the language

'Three ways' doesn't identify a division method. Confirm the method and visible charges before presenting the payment request; never ask learners to handle card credentials.

Would you like equal shares or ___?

This charge refers to ___ on the bill.

Before payment, could we confirm ___?

Compare this wording: I'll put a third on each card.

Clearer: Would you prefer equal thirds or separate checks by item?

The question avoids deciding a financial preference for the diners.

4. Check the language

1. Guest: We want everyone to pay for their own dishes.

Server: Then you want ____.

- A. three equal contributions
- B. an even split
- C. one shared total only
- D. separate checks by item

2. Guest: Our total is seventy-two dollars, and we'd like equal thirds.

Server: That's ____ each.

- A. twenty-four dollars
- B. thirty-six dollars
- C. seventy-two dollars
- D. eighteen dollars

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Three ways can mean two things

The \$72 bill in the case is unpaid.

01 • Server: Before arranging a split payment, would you like equal shares or separate checks by item?

02 • Guest: Actually, we'd each like to pay for our own food rather than divide everything equally.

03 • Server: Certainly. Equal thirds would be twenty-four dollars, but I'll prepare separate checks by item instead.

04 • Guest: Thank you. I had the pasta and water, and my colleague here had the tart.

05 • Server: Who should have the shared dessert on their check, or would you like it divided?

06 • Guest: Put the whole dessert on mine, please. I offered to treat them to that part.

07 • Server: I'll allocate the dessert to your check, and confirm the remaining drink with the third diner.

08 • Guest: That drink belongs to them. Can we see the individual bills before making any payments?

09 • Server: Yes. I'll bring the three checks back for review before asking you to pay.

10 • Guest: Great. We meant three separate bills, so I'm glad you checked before assuming equal amounts.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A charge appears twice

A guest queries a duplicate drink on an unpaid bill.

01 • Guest: The bill shows two lemonades, but I only ordered one during the whole meal.

02 • Server: Let me check the order record and the two entries before we process your payment.

03 • Guest: One line says lemonade and the other says the same thing with a later time.

04 • Server: I can see both entries. Did anyone else at your table order a second one?

05 • Guest: No. My companion had water, and there was no refill or second glass for me.

06 • Server: Thank you. The shift lead has confirmed the duplicate entry and approved its removal.

07 • Guest: Could you bring the revised bill so I can see which amount actually changed?

08 • Server: Certainly. This corrected version has one lemonade; the duplicate line is no longer charged.

09 • Guest: That matches what we had. Is this now the version we'll use for payment?

10 • Server: Yes, this revised bill is the one to review and pay, not the earlier copy.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

An optional extra is not required

A server explains a fictional bill with a labeled service charge.

01 • Guest: This bill has a service charge and another blank line. Are both amounts required?

02 • Server: The printed service charge is included in this total; the blank line is for an optional tip.

03 • Guest: So leaving that optional line blank doesn't remove the service charge already printed above it?

04 • Server: Correct. They are different entries. The total here already includes the restaurant's stated service charge.

05 • Guest: Can you tell me how that charge is distributed among the people working tonight?

06 • Server: I don't have a verified explanation of distribution. Our shift lead can answer that question.

07 • Guest: Please ask them. I want to understand the charge before deciding about an extra tip.

08 • Server: I'll bring them over, and leave the payment unprocessed while you discuss that question.

09 • Guest: Thank you. Please don't infer any optional tip amount from what we paid last time.

10 • Server: Of course. Any optional extra is your choice, not an assumption from a previous visit.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Explaining and splitting a bill

Three diners have a fictional \$72 total with all listed charges included. They request 'three ways': this could mean equal payments or separate checks by item. The restaurant supports either before payment. Ask which they mean; equal shares would be \$24.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Guest: clarify that 'three ways' means individual items; two guests shared one dessert.

Second round: The guests disagree over the shared dessert. Ask for their agreed allocation rather than choose for them.

Scenario 2 | Two payers, four diners

Four diners agree that one payer covers all food and another covers all drinks. The bill is unpaid and can be split by item.

Role A: Server: clarify the two groups of charges.

Role B: Guest: you pay for food, including the shared dessert; your companion covers drinks.

Possible opening: Would you like the food on one check and the drinks on the other?

Success checks

- Resolve the conflicting descriptions.
- Place dessert with food.
- Confirm the grouping before payment.

Add a complication: The guest initially says 'half each' but then explains the unequal item grouping.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 07 / READ AND NOTICE

Agreeing on clearing and shared service

Get permission to clear specific items without rushing the table.

SITUATION

At table 2, one diner's plate is empty but the shared vegetable dish still has food. The diner is using the plate for another portion. Ask what can be cleared; offer extra sharing plates without removing active items.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

pre-bus - Remove used items during a meal after checking that diners have finished with them.

place setting - The tableware arranged for one diner.

sharing plate - A plate provided so a diner can take a portion of a shared dish.

crumb - A small loose piece of food, especially bread, on a table or plate.

Useful word combinations

clear an empty plate: remove a plate the diner has finished using

leave the serving dish: keep the shared dish on the table

reset a place: arrange tableware for the next diner or course

ask before reaching: get the guest's attention before entering their table space

LESSON 07 / LANGUAGE AND PRACTICE

Ask about use, not appearance

3. Notice the language

An empty plate may still be in use. Use 'finished with' for an object; 'finished eating' asks about the person's meal.

Are you finished with ___?

Shall I leave ___ for now?

May I reach across to remove ___?

Compare this wording: You're done, right?

Clearer: Are you finished with this serving dish, or would you like it left here?

A specific, neutral choice avoids pressure to finish.

4. Check the language

1. Guest: I'm using this empty plate for more vegetables.

Server: I'll ____.

A. clear it now

B. leave it here

C. replace it before you continue

D. clear it with the serving dish

2. Server: Are you finished ____ the bread plate?

Guest: No, please leave it.

A. from

B. by

C. with

D. at

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

An empty plate still has a purpose

Table 2 has a shared vegetable dish, as in the case.

01 • Server: May I clear this plate, or are you still using it for the shared vegetables?

02 • Guest: Please leave it. I was just about to take another portion from that serving dish.

03 • Server: Of course. Are these two empty glasses finished with, or would you prefer them left too?

04 • Guest: You can take the glasses. We'd like to keep the water jug and our water glasses.

05 • Server: I'll clear only the two empty juice glasses, leaving the jug and all plates here.

06 • Guest: Thank you. Could we have another sharing plate for the person at the end?

07 • Server: Certainly. Would one small plate be enough, or does anyone else need one as well?

08 • Guest: Just one, please. The rest of us already have plates for the shared food.

09 • Server: Here you are. I'll leave the serving dish until you tell me you're finished with it.

10 • Guest: That's helpful. We're taking our time, but we don't need all those empty glasses.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Reaching across a conversation

A server needs permission to retrieve a dish near a guest.

01 • Server: Excuse me, may I reach across for that empty dish, or should I come around?

02 • Guest: Please come around. There's an open laptop here, and I don't want anything moved across it.

03 • Server: Certainly. I'll approach from the other side so your laptop can stay where it is.

04 • Guest: Thank you. The dish is finished, but the cup beside it still has tea inside.

05 • Server: I'll take just the dish. Would you like the cup moved closer to you?

06 • Guest: No, it's fine there. I'm waiting for the tea to cool before I drink it.

07 • Server: Understood. I'll leave the cup and its saucer exactly where you've placed them.

08 • Guest: Could you remove the unused menu too? We have everything we want for now.

09 • Server: Yes, I'll take that menu from this side without disturbing the laptop or drink.

10 • Guest: That gives us more room. Thanks for checking which things we still needed.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Enough settings for a shared dessert

Two diners want one dessert but separate spoons and plates.

01 • Guest: We're sharing one dessert. Could you bring enough tableware so we don't have to pass it around?

02 • Server: Certainly. Would you like two small plates and a spoon for each of you?

03 • Guest: Yes, please. The dessert can stay in the center while we divide it ourselves.

04 • Server: I'll bring two dessert place settings and leave room for the shared dish.

05 • Guest: Please leave our coffee cups as well, even though one looks almost empty now.

06 • Server: Of course. Are you finished with the bread basket, or is that still in use?

07 • Guest: The basket can go, but my friend is keeping the last piece on their side plate.

08 • Server: I'll remove the basket only. Your side plates and coffee cups will stay here.

09 • Guest: That sounds right. There should be plenty of space once the basket is gone.

10 • Server: Here are the dessert plates and spoons; I'll set the shared dish between you.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Agreeing on clearing and shared service

At table 2, one diner's plate is empty but the shared vegetable dish still has food. The diner is using the plate for another portion. Ask what can be cleared; offer extra sharing plates without removing active items.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Guest: your empty plate is still needed for vegetables, but the empty glasses can go.

Second round: The guest says 'take those' while pointing between glasses and plates. Clarify the items.

Scenario 2 | A guest steps away

A guest leaves the table briefly. Their companion says the main plate is still in use, but the starter plate is finished.

Role A: Server: confirm which plate can be cleared.

Role B: Companion: identify the small starter plate and ask that the main stay.

Possible opening: Which plate has your companion finished with?

Success checks

- Identify the small starter plate.
- Leave the main in place.
- Avoid inferring that the absent guest has finished.

Add a complication: Both plates contain scraps, so appearance alone does not resolve the question.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 08 / READ AND NOTICE

Handing over a live section

Name each table's status and get the incoming server's acknowledgment.

SITUATION

At 8:00 Maya takes over tables 4 and 5. Table 4's mains are served, and dessert has not been ordered. Table 5 has an open check and a pending duplicate-coffee query being reviewed by the shift lead. Ask Maya to accept both follow-ups.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

section - A group of tables assigned to a server for a period of service.

open check - A bill that has not yet been settled or closed.

side work - Support tasks outside direct table service, such as restocking napkins.

handover - A transfer of table information and outstanding tasks to another staff member.

Useful word combinations

take over a section: accept responsibility for specified tables

settle an open check: complete payment for an outstanding bill

restock the service station: replenish supplies used by servers

follow up on a request: return to an unresolved guest need

LESSON 08 / LANGUAGE AND PRACTICE

Transfer unresolved table details

3. Notice the language

Separate an open question from a completed action. A handover needs a receiver, not merely a note left at the station.

Table ___ has ___; ___ is still open.

Please check ___ before ___.

Can you take over ___ while I ___?

Compare this wording: Four and five are fine.

Clearer: Four needs a dessert check; five is waiting for a bill correction decision.

The incoming server knows what remains to do.

4. Check the language

1. Maya: Has table five paid?

Server: No, its check is still ____.

A. closed

B. open

C. duplicated

D. settled

2. Server: Can you take over the dessert check at four?

Maya: ____.

A. I saw that request on the screen

B. I thought you were checking it

C. I checked with table five earlier

D. I will check with table four

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Two tables, two different loose ends

The 8:00 handover in the case.

01 • Outgoing server: Can you take tables four and five? Four's mains are served, but they haven't ordered dessert.

02 • Maya: Yes. I'll check whether they want dessert once they've had time to finish their mains.

03 • Outgoing server: Five has an open check; the shift lead is reviewing a possible duplicate coffee charge.

04 • Maya: So I shouldn't present their current bill again as though the question were already resolved?

05 • Outgoing server: Correct. Please get the lead's decision first, then explain the confirmed outcome to the table.

06 • Maya: I'll take that follow-up too. Have either table's guests been told that I'm replacing you?

07 • Outgoing server: Not yet. I'll introduce you before I leave the section to restock the service station.

08 • Maya: Good. Is there any other food order waiting to be sent for those tables?

09 • Outgoing server: No pending food orders. The dessert preference and the coffee-charge review are the remaining tasks.

10 • Maya: Understood. I'll handle those two checks, and you can finish the station restock.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A break handover includes the limit

A server asks a colleague to cover one table during a short break.

01 • Server: I'm taking a ten-minute break. Could you cover table six without taking over my whole section?

02 • Cover server: Yes, table six only. What have they received, and is any part of their order pending?

03 • Server: Their mains have arrived. They asked for more water, but I haven't brought it yet.

04 • Cover server: I'll bring the water and check whether they need anything else while you're away.

05 • Server: Thank you. Their dessert order hasn't been discussed, so please don't assume they're finished.

06 • Cover server: Understood. If they want dessert, I'll take the order and tell you when you return.

07 • Server: The bill is also open, with no query or adjustment requested at this point.

08 • Cover server: If they ask to pay during your break, I'll handle that under our usual arrangement.

09 • Server: Please let me know afterward whether the check is still open or has been settled.

10 • Cover server: I will. Water is the immediate request, and I'll report any order or payment change.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Restocking without an assumption

Two servers divide closing support work while one table remains seated.

01 • Server: I'll do the napkin side work while you cover the remaining table. Have the clean cutlery trays arrived?

02 • Colleague: One tray has arrived, but the second is still with the dish team.

03 • Server: Then I won't mark the whole station restock complete yet. Which supplies are actually missing?

04 • Colleague: Small spoons and folded napkins. The forks and dinner knives are already stocked in their compartments.

05 • Server: I'll finish the napkins, and you can ask about the small spoons after checking the table.

06 • Colleague: That works. The table hasn't paid, so I need to stay available for their bill request.

07 • Server: I'll leave the service station accessible while they're here.

08 • Colleague: Thanks. Could you tell me when the napkins are done so I don't repeat that task?

09 • Server: They are stocked now. Only the spoon tray remains outstanding from the list we discussed.

10 • Colleague: I'll follow up with the dish team once the table's immediate request has been handled.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Handing over a live section

At 8:00 Maya takes over tables 4 and 5. Table 4's mains are served, and dessert has not been ordered. Table 5 has an open check and a pending duplicate-coffee query being reviewed by the shift lead. Ask Maya to accept both follow-ups.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Incoming server: accept both tables and repeat which bill question remains unresolved.

Second round: The shift lead has not decided about the coffee charge. Keep the question open while accepting follow-up.

Scenario 2 | A move between sections

Table 9 moves to table 19 for a quieter seat. The same unpaid order must follow the diners. The incoming server has not been briefed.

Role A: Outgoing server: explain the move and current order.

Role B: Incoming server: accept the diners at 19; their drinks have arrived and mains are pending.

Possible opening: The guests at nineteen moved from nine; they haven't placed a second order.

Success checks

- Identify old and new tables.
- Avoid duplicating the order.
- Confirm who tells the runner and follows up on the mains.

Add a complication: A runner still sees table 9 on the food ticket.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

Answer workshop

Try the tasks first. The model is one acceptable response to scenario 1, not a script to memorize. Assess your spoken version using the four criteria at the end.

01 | Confirming seats and order details

Editing example: One salad for seat two, dressing on the side and no onions.

The revised order identifies the diner and both changes.

Check 1: D - on the side

A: Mixing it through contradicts the request for separate service.

B: Pouring it over the salad doesn't keep it separate.

C: This removes the dressing rather than serving it separately.

D: Correct. The dressing arrives in a separate serving.

Check 2: D - which seat you are sitting in

A: Moving the preposition doesn't remove the need for embedded statement order.

B: This uses direct-question word order after an introductory question.

C: After 'confirm', use statement order rather than 'do you'.

D: Correct. The embedded question keeps the subject before its verb.

Model response: Before I send table twelve's order, could I check who requested no onions? I have mushroom pasta for seat one and a salad with dressing on the side for seat two. Seat three is still deciding. I'll attach the onion request to the correct dish and read those details back.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

02 | Explaining menu choices and prices

Editing example: The steak adds five dollars to the twenty-four-dollar set price.

A supplement is an addition, not the whole price.

Check 1: A - added to

A: Correct. The supplement increases the base price.

B: The supplement is added on top, not included within the base price.

C: Deducted means subtracted, not added.

D: Five dollars does not equal the set price.

Check 2: A - whereas

A: Correct. This contrasts the included items.

B: This would claim a causal relationship.

C: This would suggest an unsupported consequence and needs different punctuation.

D: This introduces a condition rather than the stated contrast.

Model response: The steak set would be twenty-nine dollars: the twenty-four-dollar set price plus a five-dollar supplement. It includes dessert and potatoes. The a la carte steak is twenty-seven dollars with potatoes but no dessert. If you don't want dessert, the separate steak costs less; the set includes the extra course.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

03 | Receiving an allergy question

Editing example: Sesame isn't mentioned here, but I need current ingredient and handling information.

Absence from a short description is not evidence of suitability.

Check 1: A - not listed here

A: Correct. This limits the claim to the visible description.

B: The description cannot establish every ingredient used.

C: No removal has been requested or confirmed.

D: The description says nothing about separate service.

Check 2: B - allergy

A: An adverb does not name the condition.

B: Correct. The singular noun follows 'an'.

C: The plural noun cannot follow 'an'.

D: An adjective cannot fill this noun position alone.

Model response: Thank you for telling me about your sesame allergy. The old menu description doesn't establish the current bun's ingredients or how it is handled. I can't confirm suitability from that description. I'll ask the kitchen lead to check your specific question before sending a food order, and bring back the verified information.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

04 | Coordinating courses and delays

Editing example: At seven thirty, the kitchen estimated another eight minutes.

The revised update gives usable timing without pretending certainty.

Check 1: A - additional

A: Correct. Additional means more time beyond what has passed.

B: Completed minutes have already elapsed.

C: Earlier moves backward rather than forward.

D: Previous refers to elapsed time.

Check 2: A - not canceled

A: Correct. Holding postpones the course without canceling its order.

B: A delay request doesn't establish that dishes are ready for collection.

C: The request concerns dishes not yet served to the diners.

D: A hold applies to an order that already exists.

Model response: We asked the kitchen to start your mains at seven twenty. One dish is still being prepared, and the current estimate is another eight minutes. I know you need to leave at seven fifty. That is an estimate, not a guaranteed serving time; would you like me to discuss your timing with the kitchen?

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

05 | Correcting a dish without blame

Editing example: You ordered pasta; this is risotto. I'm sorry for the mix-up.

The correction addresses the guest's experience without shifting blame.

Check 1: D - we brought

A: A finite verb is missing.

B: The past participle would be 'brought'.

C: Present tense does not identify this completed mistake.

D: Correct. Past tense acknowledges what happened.

Check 2: D - a newly prepared replacement dish

A: Removing a charge is a bill adjustment, not the remake itself.

B: Reheating an existing dish isn't the promised fresh preparation.

C: Canceling ends the order rather than supplying its replacement.

D: Correct. The kitchen prepares a fresh replacement for the dish.

Model response: I'm sorry we brought risotto when your order was vegetable pasta. I've checked the ticket, and it does show pasta. The kitchen can remake it, with an estimated ten-minute wait. Would that work for you? If you want to discuss a bill adjustment, I'll ask our shift lead rather than promise one myself.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

06 | Explaining and splitting a bill

Editing example: Would you prefer equal thirds or separate checks by item?

The question avoids deciding a financial preference for the diners.

Check 1: D - separate checks by item

A: Equal contributions ignore different item totals.

B: Equal shares may not match each person's items.

C: A shared total alone doesn't meet the request.

D: Correct. Items are assigned to the person paying for them.

Check 2: A - twenty-four dollars

A: Correct. Three equal shares of 72 are 24.

B: That would split the total into two shares.

C: That repeats the whole total.

D: That would split the total into four shares.

Model response: When you say three ways, would you like three equal payments or separate checks for each person's items? The total shown is seventy-two dollars, including the listed charges. Equal payments would be twenty-four dollars each. If you prefer separate checks, I'll confirm who had each item before any payment is taken.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

07 | Agreeing on clearing and shared service

Editing example: Are you finished with this serving dish, or would you like it left here?

A specific, neutral choice avoids pressure to finish.

Check 1: B - leave it here

A: The guest explicitly says the plate is still needed.

B: Correct. Leaving it respects the guest's stated use.

C: The guest hasn't requested a different plate or interruption.

D: Both items remain in use for the next portion.

Check 2: C - with

A: 'From' does not form this expression.

B: 'By' would introduce a deadline or agent in other structures.

C: Correct. 'Finished with' means no longer using something.

D: 'Finished at' would usually introduce a time or place.

Model response: May I clear the empty glasses, or are you still using them? I'll leave your plate and the shared vegetables because you're taking another portion. Would an extra sharing plate help? I can bring one and then check which serving items you're finished with, without interrupting the rest of your meal.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

08 | Handing over a live section

Editing example: Four needs a dessert check; five is waiting for a bill correction decision.

The incoming server knows what remains to do.

Check 1: B - open

A: Closed conflicts with the unpaid status.

B: Correct. An open check remains outstanding.

C: Only a possible coffee entry is duplicated, not the whole check.

D: Settled would indicate payment is complete.

Check 2: D - I will check with table four

A: Seeing the request doesn't show that Maya accepts it.

B: This states a prior assumption instead of accepting responsibility.

C: This reports earlier work at a different table.

D: Correct. Maya explicitly accepts the named table follow-up.

Model response: Maya, table four has its mains and hasn't ordered dessert. Table five's check is still open because the shift lead is reviewing a possible duplicate coffee charge. Please check on four's dessert preference and get the lead's decision before presenting five's bill again. Can you take those two follow-ups while I finish the station restock?

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and switches roles and repeats the exchange. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All people, prices, policies, counts, and incidents are fictional language practice, not food-safety, allergy, alcohol-service, legal, or payment-processing training. Follow workplace training and local requirements. Ingredient and cross-contact questions need the designated kitchen lead; do not guarantee suitability. This course concerns table service, not restaurant management.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook: Waiters and Waitresses

<https://www.bls.gov/ooh/food-preparation-and-serving/waiters-and-waitresses.htm>

O*NET OnLine: Waiters and Waitresses

<https://www.onetonline.org/link/summary/35-3031.00>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the following prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Vocabulary and grammar prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has four practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

Each starter prompt uses B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-30. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Practice grammar in context

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT | ONLINE VERSION

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Restaurant Serving English

Professional audience: Restaurant servers, food runners, and dining-room service staff

Scope: All people, prices, policies, counts, and incidents are fictional language practice, not food-safety, allergy, alcohol-service, legal, or payment-processing training. Follow workplace training and local requirements. Ingredient and cross-contact questions need the designated kitchen lead; do not guarantee suitability. This course concerns table service, not restaurant management.

Lesson 01: Confirming seats and order details

Original fictional case: Table 12 has three covers. Seat one orders mushroom pasta, seat two orders a salad with dressing separately, and seat three has not chosen. The phrase 'no onions' was spoken without a clear seat reference. Clarify before sending the order.

Language workshop: Attach each change to a dish

Communication goal: Clarify an ambiguous modifier and confirm the complete order.

Language guidance: A modifier needs a dish and a diner. 'On the side' means separately, not omitted. Ask a focused question before reading back the order.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): Was ___ for your ___ or for ___? / I have ___ for seat ___, with ___. / You're still deciding on ___; is that right?

Vocabulary: cover: One diner counted for restaurant table service. / seat number: A numbered position at a table used to match an order to a diner. / modifier: An order detail that changes the standard dish, such as sauce on the side. / read-back: A spoken repetition of an order so the guest can correct it.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Guest at seat two: confirm that no onions applies to your salad, not the pasta. Seat three needs another minute.

Guided response task: Complete a workplace dialogue by selecting one of four supplied options. Compare the feedback and say the completed exchange aloud. Do not write an open-ended message.

Optional second-round challenge: Seat one also wants dressing for a side salad. Keep that request separate from seat two's main salad.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: Before I send table twelve's order, could I check who requested no onions? I have mushroom pasta for seat one and a salad with dressing on the side for seat two. Seat three is still deciding. I'll attach the onion request to the correct dish and read those details back.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Choose grammar that preserves the meaning

1. Use the lesson's language workshop, or one actual sentence from the dialogue, to explain a single grammar distinction in no more than 90 words. Show how it affects timing, certainty, responsibility or politeness.
2. Give one brief occupational exchange containing a gap and four complete options A-D. Supply enough context for exactly one answer. Keep distractors plausible; distinguish grammar errors from wording that changes the facts. Stop and wait.
3. Explain why each choice fits or fails, then ask me to read the completed exchange aloud. Do not request a draft, original written sentence or essay.
4. Repeat with three new exchanges, one at a time, moving from recognition to a more subtle meaning contrast. Do not copy the published checks. Label invented variations and do not turn uncertainty into a promise.
5. End with a short contrast table and two supported spoken turns using supplied frames. Accept accurate alternatives in oral practice; acknowledge and replace ambiguous multiple-choice items.

END PROMPT